

Vim

Editor Essentials

Vim (Vi Improved) is a text editor that is one of the direct derivatives, and one of the prime ingredients of the UNIX hacker culture. With its extensive support and simplicity, Vim stands out as a unique text editor with numerous features. It's both simple and powerful!

We come across numerous GUI text editors like KWrite and Gedit, with which you need to use the mouse extensively to access some of the features. Unlike these, Vim doesn't support the mouse. Instead, it stays close to the command-line with extensive key-bindings support. Many believe this is a feature, because it facilitates better control over text processing with simple commands.

This article will focus on how Vim can help get going with your text editing tasks. If you are new to Vim, open a terminal session and type the following command:

```
$ vim test.txt
```

This will launch the editor. Press 'i' and start writing. You might feel a bit awkward at this stage since you are more comfortable with GUI text editors and probably might think: what's the point? Well, Vim has its many advantages. Let's create a large file using the **dd** command,

filled with 0s. Now open that file in GUI editors like Gedit or KWrite. What happens? It takes a lot of time to render the text, and eventually crashes, right? Now, try to open it with Vim, and see the difference.

Let us have a roundup of the treasures of Vim:

- Mode-controlled text editing
- Regular expressions support
- Text replacement, searching, deletion
- Auto completion
- Auto indentation
- Split windows
- Multiple file tabs
- Syntax colouring
- Dictionary
- Better help
- Sleek and simple

Installing Vim

On most of the distros, Vim is installed by default. However, if you're on an Ubuntu system like me, you'll need to download a few extra packages to get the full functionality.